
When you read a story, do you think
about why the author wrote it?
Who was it written for, and when was it
written?

UNDERSTANDING AUDIENCE, PURPOSE AND CONTEXT

PRESENTER:

FACULTY OF GENERAL EDUCATION

DIHPE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES



Recognize the author's purpose in a given text.



Analyse the context of a text.



Identify the target audience for a text and how the author has tailored their message to that audience.

Purpose

- What is the goal of the author? (to inform, to entertain, to teach a lesson, to instruct, to persuade)
- Why is the text written?

Audience

- Who are the intended readers?
- What do they already know and what are they unaware of?
- How will it affect them?

Context

- What was happening in the world at that time?
- How does historical, social, or cultural background affect the text's meaning?

Read the statements and identify PAC for each.

1. For effective plaque control, patients should brush twice daily using a fluoride-containing toothpaste. Brushing should be systematic, ensuring that all tooth surfaces are adequately cleaned.
2. I understand that you are worried about the procedure. Before we decide on treatment, let me explain what we have found and what your options are.
3. Patient reports spontaneous pain in relation to 36 for three days, aggravated by cold. Deep carious lesion noted clinically. IOPA advised to assess pulpal and periapical status.
4. Ignoring persistent bleeding while brushing is not advisable. Although occasional bleeding may seem insignificant, it can indicate underlying periodontal inflammation and should be professionally assessed.
5. The findings indicate a significant association between frequent consumption of fermentable carbohydrates and increased caries experience among participants. Further investigation is required to establish causality.
6. I went to the clinic because I was in unbearable pain, but instead of treating me immediately, they made me wait, took an X-ray, and started explaining different options. I left without getting the tooth removed.

An Encounter with an Interviewer

by

Mark Twain

Pre-Reading Task (20 minutes)

- Work in groups, create a poster, and share with class.
- Group A: Research about the Author.
 - Q1. Who was Mark Twain (real name, background, career)?
 - Q2. How did people view him and what kind of writing was he most famous for?
- Group B: Research about “An Encounter with an Interviewer”.
 - Q1. What is this text about (basic summary)?
 - Q2. What type of text is it and what tone/ style does Twain use in it?
- Group C: Research about the era in which it was written.
 - Q1. What was happening in America when Twain wrote (social/cultural/technological changes)?
 - Q2. What role did newspapers and journalism play in society at the time?

Group A: Research about the Author

Q1:

- **Real name:** Samuel Langhorne Clemens.
- **Born:** November 30, 1835, in Florida, Missouri, USA.
- **Background:** Many of his writings were inspired by the Mississippi River town of Hannibal, Missouri, where he grew up.
- **Career:** Before becoming one of America's finest writers, he worked as a printer, riverboat pilot, miner, journalist, and lecturer. His pen name, Mark Twain, is a riverboat navigation word that means "two fathoms deep."

Q2:

- Mark Twain's wit, humour, and astute social observations won him admiration.
- He was regarded as one of the best public speakers and writers in America.
- His hilarious tales, satire, adventure books, and social criticism were his most well-known works.
- The Adventures of Tom Sawyer and Adventures of Huckleberry Finn are two of his most well-known novels.

Group B: Research about "An Encounter with an Interviewer"

Q1:

- The narrative centers on Mark Twain's amusing encounter with an interviewer.
- The interviewer asks strange, personal, and exaggerated questions instead of sensible ones.
- Twain effectively responds, mocking sensational journalism with wit and irony.

Q2:

- **Type of text:** Humorous essay (satire).
- **Tone:** Funny, sarcastic, witty, and ironic.
- **Style:** Twain uses exaggeration, clever dialogue, and satire to criticize the behavior of reporters and newspapers.

Group C: Research about the Era in Which It Was Written

Q1:

- Rapid industrial growth and urbanization.
- Telephone, telegraph, and improved printing presses changed communication.
- Newspapers and magazines became very popular.
- Society was changing quickly, and writers often commented on these changes.

Q2.

- Newspapers were the main source of news and entertainment.
- Because there was fierce competition among newspapers, some reporters utilised dramatic headlines and overstated reporting to draw readers.
- Interviews with celebrities gained popularity.
- Mark Twain used satire to criticize reporters who cared more about exciting stories than about accuracy.

Reading Task (10 minutes)

Read the text “An Encounter with an Interviewer”.

Post-Reading Task (20 minutes)

A. Purpose

- What seems to be Twain's main purpose in writing "An Encounter with an Interviewer"?
- Why does Twain use humor and exaggeration in the piece?

B. Audience

- Who might Twain have expected to read "An Encounter with an Interviewer"?
- Which parts of the sketch might still appeal to a modern audience, and which parts might not?

C. Context

- Aaron Burr was a former Vice President of the US who died in 1836.
- What does that context help you understand about Twain's meeting with Burr?

Answers

A. Purpose

- To entertain readers while criticizing sensational journalism and foolish interviewers through satire and humor.
- In addition to making the story fascinating, he employs humour and exaggeration to highlight the ridiculous actions of certain reporters and the untrustworthiness of dramatic interviews.

B. Audience

- Twain expected newspaper readers, educated adults, and people who enjoyed humorous and satirical writing to read the piece.
- **Still appealing:** Twain's wit, cynicism, humorous banter, and critique of the media are still popular.
- **Less appealing:** Some historical allusions and archaic terminology could be challenging for contemporary readers to comprehend.

C. Context

- Twain could never have met Aaron Burr because he passed away before Twain was born.
- This demonstrates Twain's intentional exaggeration and humour, which makes the narrative satirical and fictional.

Follow-up Task

- Answer the questions in the following PCA table.

Character	Purpose	Audience	Context
Interviewer	In what way does the interviewer's persistence contribute to the message Twain is sending?	What kind of reaction might journalists have had when reading this portrayal?	What does the interviewer reveal about the way journalism worked in Twain's time?
Mark Twain	What might Twain be suggesting by giving the interviewer such little control over the conversation?	What image of himself is Twain creating for his readers here?	In what ways might Twain's position as a well-known writer influence how this character comes across?

Follow-up Task

- Answer the questions in the following PCA table.

Character	Purpose	Audience	Context
Interviewer	The interviewer's perseverance demonstrates how some media prioritised sensational stories over factual information.	Twain's funny portrayal may make journalists laugh or take offence, prompting them to consider ethical reporting.	The interview shows that in order to draw readers, journalism in Twain's period sometimes relied on inflated, intimate, and amusing interviews.
Mark Twain	Twain parodies spectacular journalism and draws attention to the interviewer's stupidity by granting them control.	Readers are impressed by Twain's sense of humour because he portrays himself as clever, witty, composed, and quick-witted.	Twain's status as a well-known author enables him to employ satire skilfully, demonstrating assurance while denouncing journalists' methods.

THANK YOU

Reference:

<https://pressbooks.howardcc.edu/engl087/chapter/audience-purpose-context/>